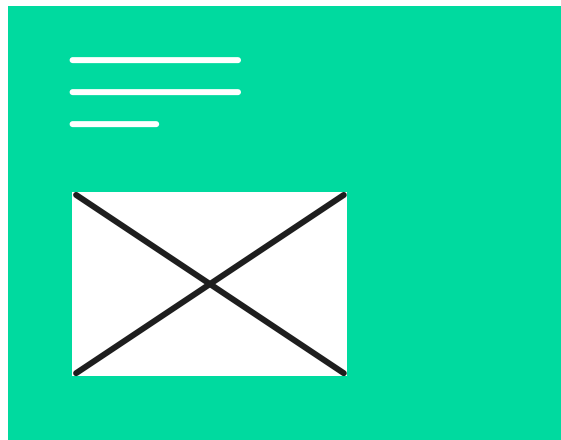




CommUnity

Local Volunteering & Community Connection
App



Team Overview



Kanishk Tawde



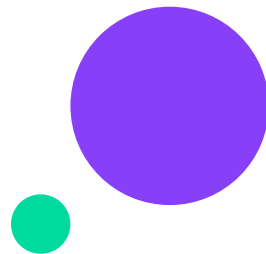
Devesh Bhatia



Shivpriya Mane



Rajath Kiran



Overview

Problem

People want to contribute and meet others with shared interests but struggle to find local opportunities

Solution

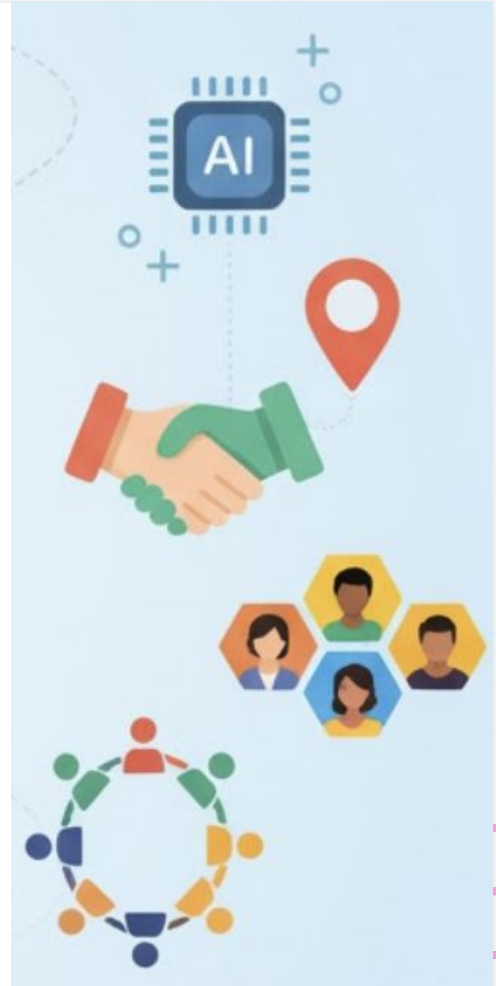
An AI-powered app that connects users with nearby volunteering and community events, and helps them network through shared causes

Concept

A blend of VolunteerMatch + Meetup + Bumble for Friends, designed for meaningful, purpose-driven connections

USP

CommUnity uniquely combines AI-powered event discovery, purpose-driven social networking, gamified engagement, and verified community events into a single platform — making local volunteering simple, meaningful, and motivating.



What is the need for such app?

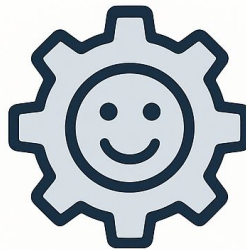
- Current apps lack personalization and community focus
- Volunteering info is scattered across platforms
- Users face low motivation and unclear sign-up flows
- No AI-driven event suggestions to match interests or schedules



VOLUNTEER



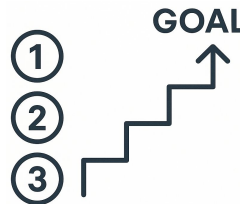
CONNECT



**AI
RECOMMENDATIONS**



Product Objectives



- Simplify discovery and registration for local volunteering events
- Enable AI-based recommendations for users and events
- Encourage networking through shared interests
- Allow users to suggest or organize community events
- Gamify engagement through badges or milestones
- Verify events and organizers for trust and safety
- Offer flexible, interest-based scheduling
- Promote long-term community engagement



Design Process

We followed the Design Thinking process to ensure CommUnity is a user-centered and impact-driven community platform.

Empathize

- Used empathy mapping to understand user motivations, anxieties, and pain points around volunteering

Define

- Identified the core problem: difficulty discovering trusted, relevant local volunteering opportunities

Ideate

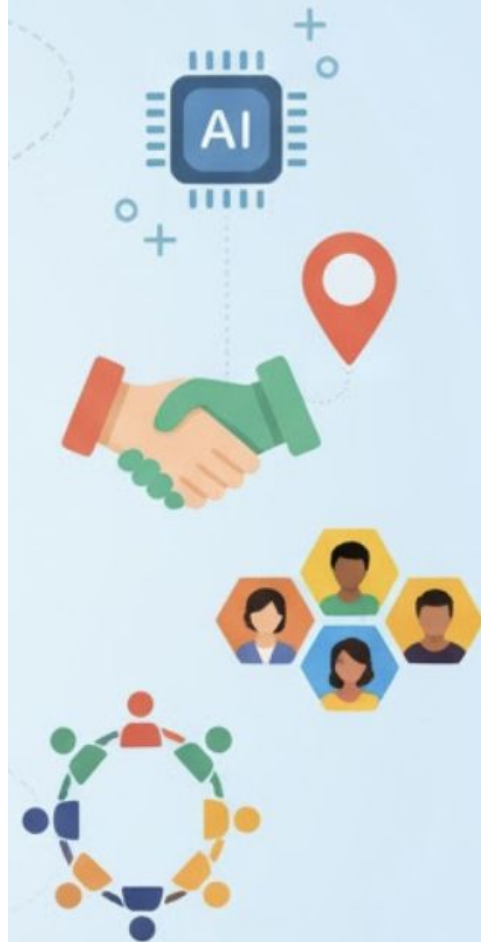
- Brainstormed solutions such as AI-based recommendations, gamification, and purpose-driven social networking

Deliver

- Created storyboards and information architecture to design seamless discovery-to-sign-up flows

Test

- Validate usability through user feedback and iterate on clarity, trust, and engagement



Who can be our Target Audience?



Ryan Thompson

Job Title. **Software Engineer**

Gender. **Male**

Family **New I.city**

Bio

Ryan recently moved to a new city and wants to engage with the local community. He is passionate about social causes, especially making a positive impact in his spare time.

Extrovert

Introvert



Tech Savvy

Novice



Organized

Messy



Liberal

Conservative



GOALS & VALUES

Goals: Establish connections and commitments to a local social causes in his new city.

Values: Empathy, Community, Impact, Initiative, Fulfillment

Motivations: Engagement. Meaningful connections

PAIN POINTS

Fears: Isolation in new city, lack of belonging

Frustrations: Uncertain about where to start, difficulty finding volunteer options



Who can be our Target Audience?



Aisha Patel

Job Title: **Graduate Student**
Gender: **Female**
Family and Social Setting: **Lives with roommates**
Income: **\$12,000/year** (assistantship)

Bio

Aisha is a 24-year-old student passionate about sustainability and animal welfare. She wants to volunteer during weekends but struggles to find well-organized local events. She's social but cautious, preferring apps that are safe and inclusive.

GOALS & VALUES

Goals: Volunteer regularly in environmental and animal care initiatives
Meet new people who share similar causes

Build a strong community network and outstated across multiple sites

Motivations: Social connection, purpose driven impact

Extrovert ————— Introvert



Tech Savvy ————— Novice



Organized ————— Messy



Liberal ————— Conservative



PAIN POINTS

Fears: Joining events that feel unorganized or unsafe

Frustrations: Event details are scattered and outdated across multiple sites. Hard to stay consistent without reminders or motivation



User Pain Points



Hard to find verified, local volunteering opportunities



Overwhelming, scattered event listings



Anxiety about attending events alone



Lack of personalized suggestions



Poorly organized sign-up processes



Difficulty maintaining engagement after events



Lack of emotional connection or follow-up



How Each UX Plane Shaped Our Project

- **Strategy Plane – Defining Purpose & User Needs:**

- Identified the core problem: People want to contribute locally but struggle to find relevant opportunities and like-minded individuals.
- Defined the solution vision: An AI-powered app connecting users to nearby volunteering events and people with shared community interests.
- Clarified primary user needs: discover events easily, meet aligned people, feel safe and welcomed in community spaces.
- Established business goals: increase community engagement, provide value through AI-driven, personalized recommendations.

- **Scope Plane – Requirements & Prioritization (MoSCoW)**

- Must-Have: User profiles, geolocation, event feed, AI recommendations, interest matching, messaging.
- Should-Have: Groups/communities, verified organizers, event reminders.
- Could-Have: Gamification, badges, volunteer hours tracker.
- Won't-Have (now): Paid memberships, organizer analytics dashboards.
- Non-functional requirements: usability, safety, reliability, data privacy.
- This plane helped define the exact features needed to bring the concept (VolunteerMatch + Meetup + Bumble for Friends) to life.

- **Structure Plane – Information Architecture & Interaction Flow**

- Built the navigation model of the app: Home Feed → Event Details → Creator Profile, designed user flows, e.g Onboarding → Select interests → AI suggests events → User joins event → Connects with attendees.
- Established structural logic: clear categories (Events, People, tickets) to reduce cognitive load.
- Ensured the interaction design supports goal-focused behavior: discover → join → connect.

- **Skeleton Plane – Layout, Wireframes & Interface Design**

- Created low-fidelity and mid-fidelity wireframes for key screens like home, event detail, profile and match.
- Designed content prioritization so most important actions are easy to find (e.g., “Join Event,” “Book slot” “Message”).
- Established placement of UI components: navigation bar, search, CTAs, and cards.

- **Surface Plane – Visual Design & Final Look**

- Developed the visual identity: friendly, modern, community-oriented tone.
- Chose a color palette symbolizing trust, positivity, and social connection.
- Applied consistent iconography, typography, spacing, and accessibility contrast ratios.
- Final screens communicate a polished experience: engaging event cards, warm photos, and intuitive interactions.

Design System

Typography

Aa

Font
Helvetica

Aa Helvetica
Bold

Aa Helvetica
Semibold

Aa Helvetica
Medium

Aa Helvetica
Regular

Name	Font Size	Line Height
Heading 1	24 px	36 px
Heading 2	20 px	28 px
Body - Large	18 px	24 px
Body - Regular	16 px	24 px
Body - Small	14 px	22 px
Caption	12 px	16 px
BUTTON	16 px	24 px

Style Guide

Color Palette

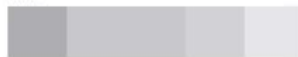
Primary Color



Shades



Tints



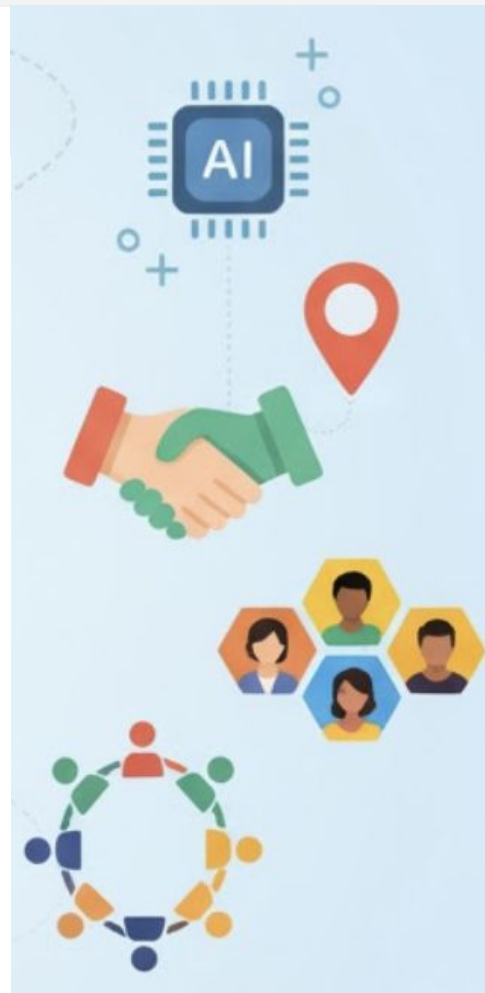
Secondary Color

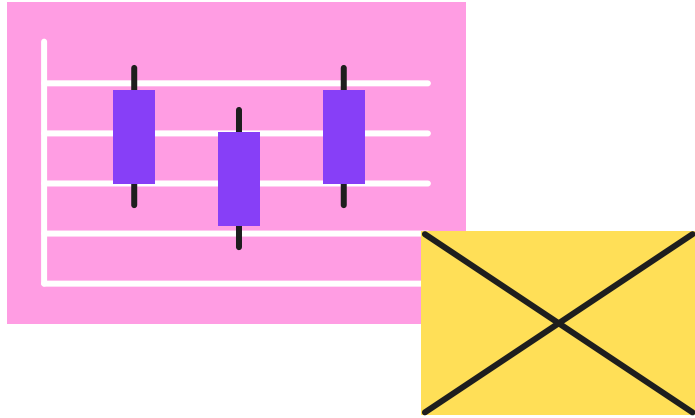
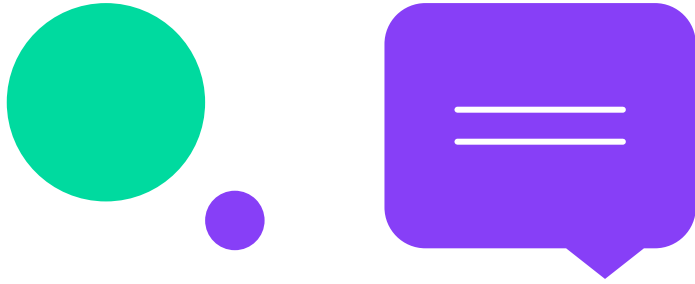


Shades



Tints

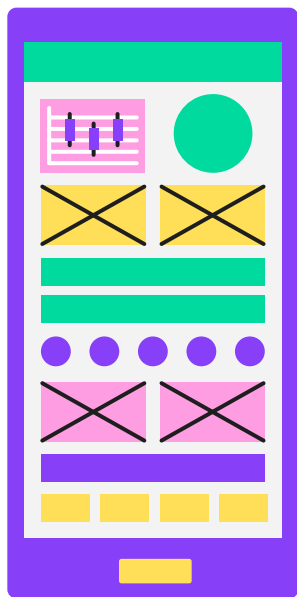




User Research Methods



Reasons for choosing Empathy Mapping



Gain Deeper Insights

What makes your product unique?



User-Centered Design

Showcase the design of your product



Understand The User

A method to grasp your user's complete experience



Team Alignment

When is the product expected to be ready?



Overview of Empathy Mapping

Says: What the user says out loud

An empathy map is a simple chart that organizes user research. It is divided into four main quadrants

Does: The user's actions and behaviors

Thinks: What is on the user's mind

This structure provides a clear picture of the user's perspective and motivations

Feels: The user's emotional state



Needs and Benefits of Empathy Mapping

Identify pain points

Helps your team understand user motivations and frustrations

Leads to better products

The main benefit is creating a user-centered design that solves real problems

Reveals conflicts

Shows gaps between what users say and what they actually do

Builds Empathy

The process fosters a deeper sense of empathy for the user within your design team

Clarifies priorities

Uncovers what is most important to the user

Synthesize research data

Visualizes and organizes qualitative research data for clear action



Empathy Map: The Aspiring Volunteer

SAYS

- "I want to do something meaningful with my free time"
- "I wish there was an easier way to sign up for events"
- "How do I find local volunteer opportunities?"
- "I want to meet people who care about the same things I do"
- "My schedule is tight. I need flexible options"

THINKS

- "I wonder if I'm qualified enough for these roles"
- "I hope the experience is well-organized and impactful"
- "Going to an event alone seems intimidating"
- "Finding the right fit is taking too much effort and time"
- "I feel disconnected from my community"

DOES

- Searches online for "volunteer events near me"
- Asks friends if they know of any local groups
- Browses confusing non-profit websites
- Follows community groups on social media for event news
- Abandons sign-up forms that are too long

FEELS

- Frustrated when searching for opportunities is difficult
- Hopeful about the idea of making a positive impact
- Anxious about meeting new people at an event
- Overwhelmed by the lack of clear, centralized information
- Motivated to find a way to contribute to the community



Overview of SWOT Analysis

SWOT Analysis helps us evaluate our Local Volunteering & Community Connection App by examining key internal and external factors that influence its success

Through SWOT, we can:

- **Strengths** – Simplifies how users discover nearby volunteer opportunities
- **Weaknesses** – Relies on event organizers for updated listings and accuracy
- **Opportunities** – AI-driven recommendations, gamified participation, local NGO/college partnerships
- **Threats** – Competition from Meetup, low engagement risk, privacy or data concerns

By applying SWOT, we gain a clear strategic understanding of our position in the market—helping us design impactful, user-centered features that make local volunteering more connected, engaging, and effortless



Reasons for SWOT Analysis

We selected SWOT Analysis because it helps us strategically evaluate both our app idea and the existing volunteering market

For our Local Volunteering & Community Connection App, this method helps us identify:

- **Strengths** – Key features that make our platform valuable for community members
- **Weaknesses** – UX gaps or limitations in current platforms like *Meetup* or *VolunteerMatch*
- **Opportunities** – Innovative possibilities through AI-driven recommendations, interest-based matching, and local partnerships
- **Threats** – Competitive risks, changing user behavior, and low engagement challenges

By using SWOT, we ensure our design is both user-centered and market-aware, aligning our UX goals with real-world community needs



SWOT- Needs and Benefits

● Needs

- Understand what motivates people to join community events and volunteer causes
- Identify why current apps fail to sustain engagement
- Discover which features — such as interest-based filters or nearby event alerts — make volunteering effortless
- Define design priorities aligned with both user goals and community needs

● Benefits

- Generate actionable insights to help our app stand out in a crowded networking space
- Guide UI/UX design toward simplicity, motivation, and trust-building
- Focus on features that drive community impact, not just engagement
- Promote data-driven design by balancing user needs with market awareness
- Strengthen team collaboration through a shared understanding of success



SWOT Matrix

STRENGTHS

- User-friendly interface focused on local volunteering
- AI-driven recommendations that match users to causes based on interests
- Integrated chat and community features for volunteer coordination
- Gamified participation (badges, milestones) to boost engagement

WEAKNESS

- Limited initial event listings dependent on organizers
- Requires user location access, raising potential privacy concerns
- Lack of immediate trust or visibility compared to established competitors
- Early-stage app may lack brand partnerships or sponsor support

OPPORTUNITIES

- Rising interest in social impact and local community involvement among youth
- Integration with schools, NGOs, and local businesses to boost awareness
- Use of AI for personalized event suggestions and impact tracking
- Potential for collaborations with city councils for verified volunteer listings

THREATS

- Competition from large event platforms like Meetup or Nextdoor
- Low user retention if event frequency or quality drops
- Privacy and data-sharing concerns around user profiles and locations
- Shifting user behavior post-pandemic affecting in-person participation



Storyboarding

Visualizing the User Journey for "CommUnity"

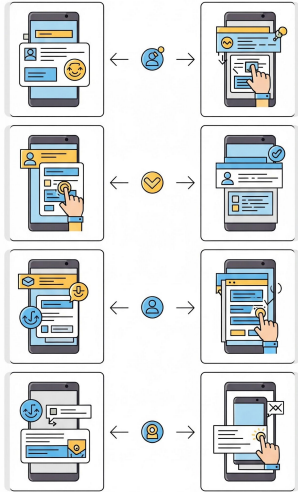
User Story:

As a local looking to step up and connect,
I'd love to see relevant local events pop up and lock in my spot
with zero fuss,
so I can stop wishing I volunteered and actually start doing it



What is Storyboarding & Why it's Key for Us

UX STORYBOARD



What it is?

Storyboarding is a sequential visual narrative that illustrates a user's experience over time

Like a comic strip, it depicts key moments:

- User (context, motivations)
- Scenario & Actions
- Thoughts & Emotions
- Product Interaction & Outcome

Why we chose it?

- Visual Empathy: Depicts emotional journey from desire to fulfillment
- Clarifies User Flow: Makes "discovery to sign-up" tangible
- Identifies Opportunities: Pinpoints delight/friction points early
- Communicates Effectively: Aligns team & stakeholders on ideal UX



Needs & Benefits of Storyboarding



Benefits

- Enhanced Empathy: Deeper human-centered understanding
- Shared Vision: Aligns team on ideal user experience
- Early Usability Insights: Uncovers potential flow breakdowns
- Holistic View: Illustrates full interaction arc to satisfaction

Needs

- Discovery Gap: How users find events (or don't)
- Match Visualization: Seeing AI-driven recommendations in action
- Decision Context: Emotional cues for event commitment
- Seamless Onboarding: Intuitive path from discovery to sign-up



The Storyboarding

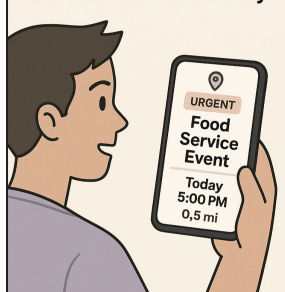
1. *The Stirring of Conscience: User feels a desire to help with local hunger*

The Stirring of Conscience



2. *Location-Based Discovery: App instantly presents a nearby, food service event*

Location-Based Discovery



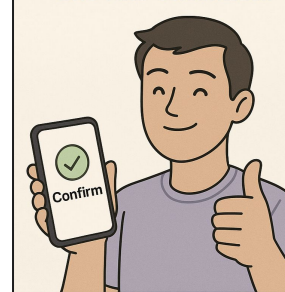
3. *Quick Details & Time Slot: User verifies event details and available slots, confirming it fits their schedule*

Quick Details & Time Slot



4. *"Zero-Fuss" Confirmation: User quickly confirms their spot with minimal interaction*

Zero-Fuss' Confirmation

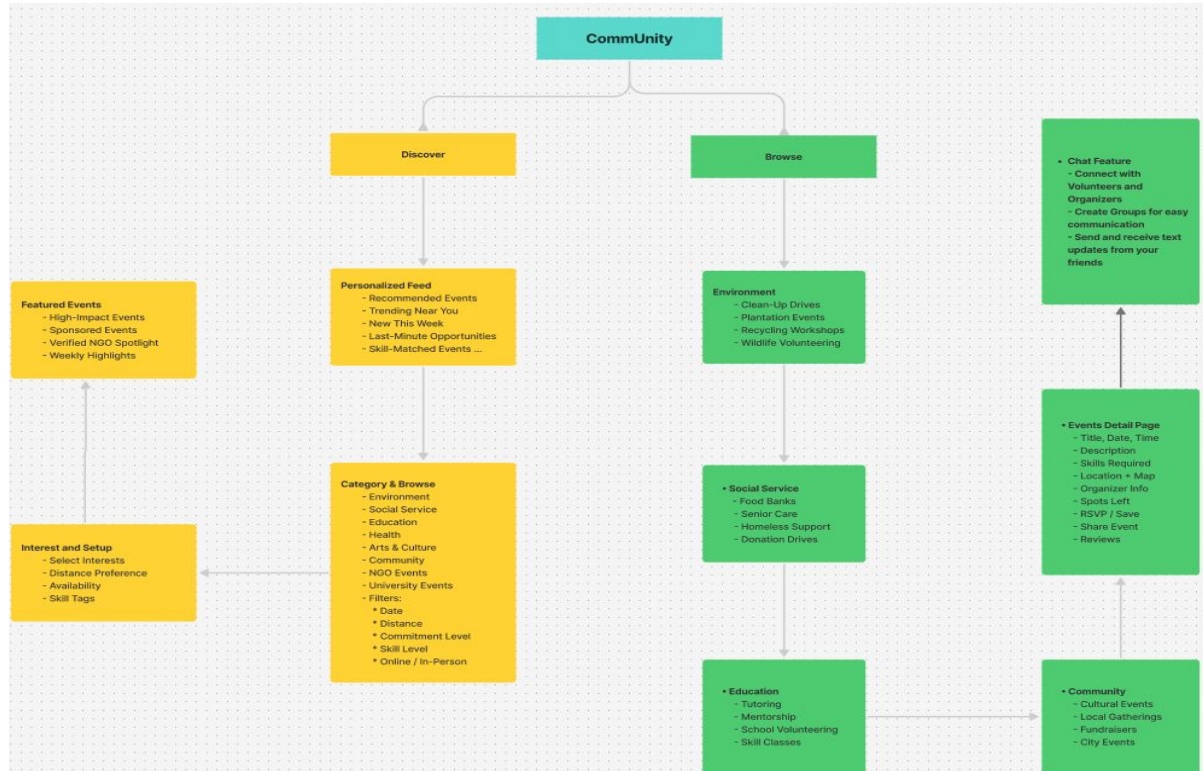


5. *Ready to Serve & Impact: Confirmation screen shows success and emphasizes the positive impact they're about to make*

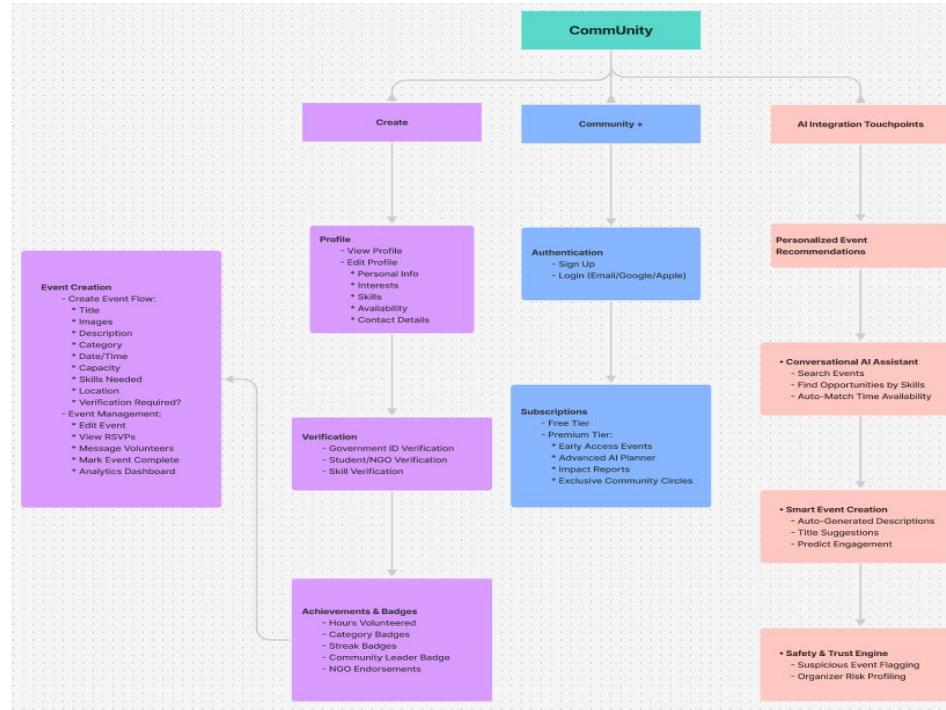
Ready to Serve & Impact



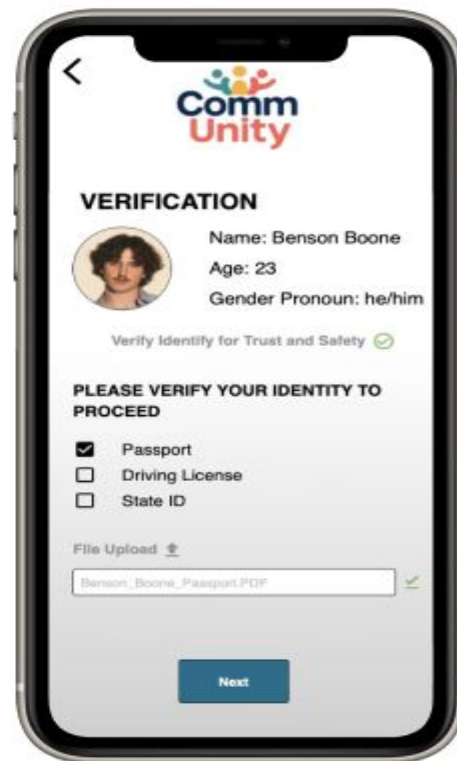
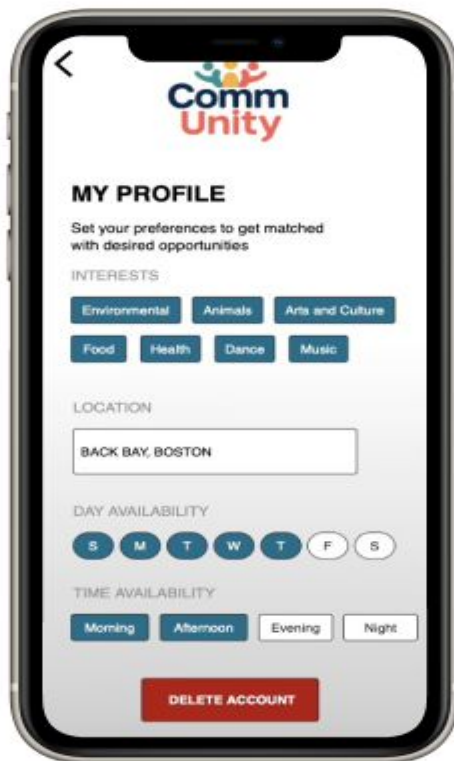
Information Architecture



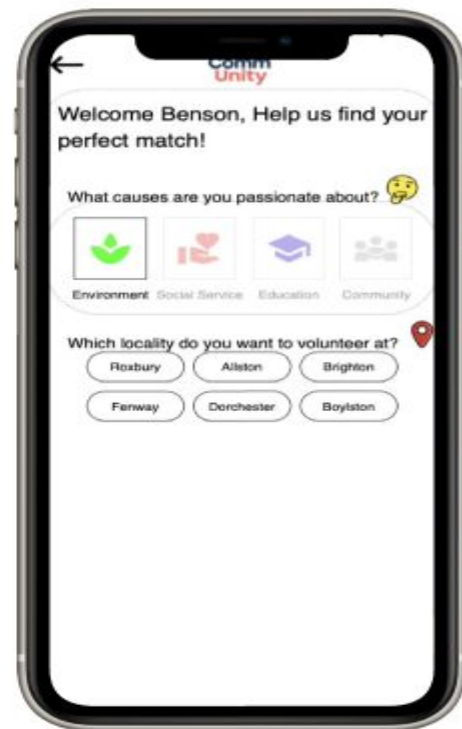
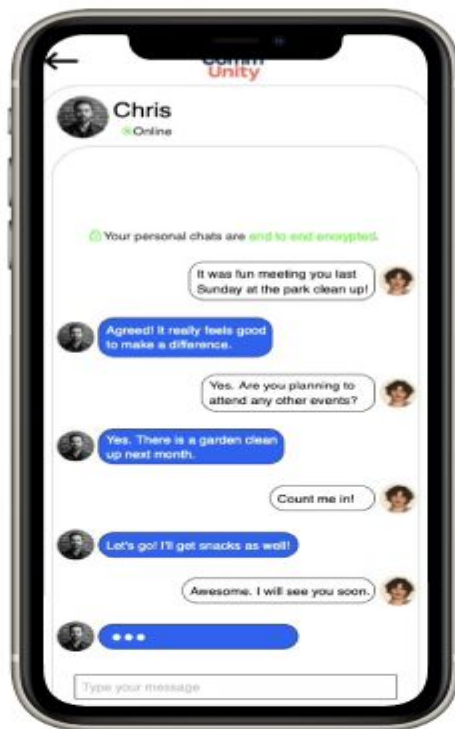
Information Architecture



Wireframes



Wireframes



AI Integration

- Problem it Solves:
AI addresses the challenge of personalizing volunteer opportunities and improving event discovery by matching users with events that align with their interests, location, and skill levels
- How AI Improves UX/Personalization:
 - Personalized Recommendations: AI analyzes user preferences, location, and past behavior to recommend the most relevant volunteer opportunities, reducing the time and effort users spend searching
- Example Prompt, Model, or Data Flow:
 - Prompt: "Show me volunteer events near me related to environmental conservation this weekend"
 - AI Model: A collaborative filtering model that matches user profiles with event details based on past behaviors and preferences
 - Data Flow:
 1. User Input: User provides preferences (interest, location, availability)
 2. Data Processing: AI processes this input along with data on available events (location, date, type)
 3. Output: AI delivers a curated list of relevant volunteer opportunities based on the user's profile

MoSCoW Approach

Must-Have

- AI-powered event recommendations
- User registration & personalized onboarding
- Event discovery and seamless sign-up
- Verified organizers for trust and safety

Should-Have

- Event chats and volunteer networking
- Gamified engagement (badges & milestones)
- Event creation tools for organizers

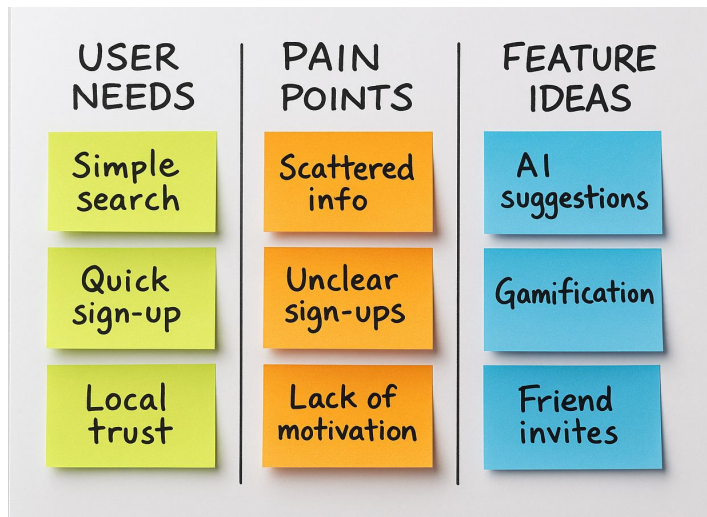
Could-Have

- Smart notifications and reminders
- Accessibility and inclusivity filters

Won't-Have (Future Scope)

- AI-based community impact analytics
- AR-enabled virtual volunteering tours

Supporting Documentation



Conclusion

- Key Findings:
 - a. Storyboarding revealed that users face frustration when trying to navigate complex volunteer platforms and need a simple, visual guide to understand the process
 - b. SWOT Analysis revealed our strengths in simplicity and personalization, highlighted trust and event availability as areas to improve, and uncovered opportunities in partnerships and gamified engagement to build a stronger community platform
 - c. Empathy Mapping Users feel uncertain and disconnected when searching for volunteer opportunities, seeking clear, personalized, and approachable experiences to overcome anxiety and find meaningful connections
- Next Steps:

We'll design app mockups that address these pain points, improving the interface and user flow to boost engagement and participation

Future Scope

CommUnity can be expanded beyond its initial release to enhance impact, scalability, and innovation:

- AI-Powered Impact Analytics to track long-term community outcomes and volunteer contributions
- Advanced Personalization using behavior-based recommendations and skill matching
- Accessibility Enhancements for diverse user needs and inclusive participation
- Emerging Technologies such as AR/VR previews of volunteer sites (long-term vision)

Goal: Scale CommUnity into a comprehensive, trusted ecosystem for local community engagement.

References

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IDEO. (2015). *Design Thinking for Innovation*

Cooper, A., Reimann, R., & Cronin, D. (2014). *About Face: The Essentials of Interaction Design*

VolunteerMatch – <https://www.volunteermatch.org>

Meetup – <https://www.meetup.com>

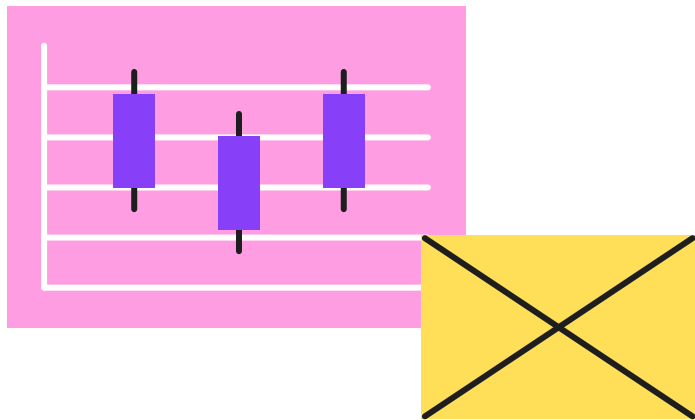
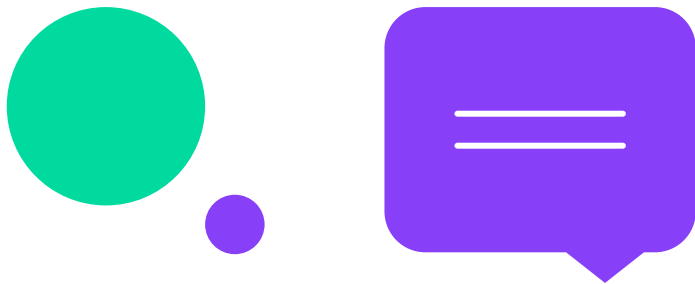
Nielsen, J. (1994). *Usability Engineering*

MoSCoW Method – Agile Business Consortium

Prototype Link

Figma App Link:

<https://www.figma.com/design/Vj9QigpPDVQCLdiJF3kmD2/CommUnity?node-id=0-1&t=c9k3KIDPyI50Ahj5-1>



THANK YOU!

